

Oconee County Council bans Flock cameras. What's next?

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OCONEE COUNTY, S.C. ([WSPA](#)) -- Oconee County Council passed an ordinance Tuesday banning the use of Flock cameras.

The ordinance bars the use of county money, property, personnel, or roads to support Flock or other mass-surveillance technology.

"We didn't take an oath to wait until a higher body took action and we didn't take an oath for a court to tell us we crossed the line. The oath says defend the constitution right where we stand," said Matthew Durham, the chairman of Oconee County Council.

Durham has been vocal about the ordinance, saying there must be legislation and guardrails put in place.

"A warrant acts as windshield at the front it's protection between you and your private information and the government," he said. "These guard rails that company puts in place is after the fact, after someone's rights been violated if it's even caught at all."

7NEWS also received a statement from Oconee County Sheriff Mike Crenshaw about what comes next.

"Our next steps are to continue advocating for legislation that places some guardrails on this technology in order to allow law enforcement to continue to use it to help keep our citizens safe," the statement reads.

"Whether it's requiring a judicial search warrant or limiting the number of cameras per square mile as two examples," Crenshaw said.

Durham said the cameras operated by the sheriff's office were purchased through the data-processing line item in the sheriff's budget that's allocated by the county.

He said the sheriff's office did not need authorization from County Council to buy the technology.

"I think anything over \$40,000 purchase would require coming before county council," Durham continued. "This was \$15,000 per year which is well below that threshold."

The sheriff's office began installing Flock cameras in 2022.

County council requested Wednesday that Flock remove the five cameras within 14 days.

The ordinance, however, does not prevent individual municipalities from using their own surveillance systems. If those areas choose to continue use of Flock cameras, they will not be eligible for discretionary funding from the county.

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